

387 out of 3,884 men in February 1863. Altogether more than 4,000 of its captives never saw their homes in the South again; many of them lie buried in one mass grave in Chicago's Oak Woods Cemetery.

By far the highest overall mortality rate of any Union prisoner-of-war camp—reaching a staggering 24 percent—was recorded at Elmira. Located in western New York State, Elmira (or "Hellmira," as it was known to its inmates) first opened on July 6, 1864, when 400 Southern prisoners were marched into a former barracks that might have held 5,000. Although it was a large camp, Elmira was nowhere near big enough for the 9,500 men it held when the population was at its peak. Many of them had to sleep outdoors in New York's freezing winter, without blankets or any other provision for shelter. Nearly 3,000 men died there—the majority from exposure, disease, and malnutrition—in the 12 months that Elmira operated.



Record death toll

Of the 150 prison camps operating during the Civil War, Camp Douglas in Chicago had the highest death rate for any one-month period, with some ten percent of its captives perishing in February 1863.